

The Strength to Stay Steady

Sabr Under Pressure

THE VALUE Sabr

THE SCIENCE Window of tolerance

THE SHIFT Breathe before pressure takes over

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اسْتَعِينُوا بِالصَّبْرِ وَالصَّلَاةِ ۚ إِنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَ الصَّابِرِينَ

“O believers, seek help through patience and prayer. Indeed, Allah is with the patient.”

Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:153

The Prophet ﷺ said: “Whoever remains patient, Allah will make him patient. No one can be given a blessing better and greater than patience.”

Source: Sahih al-Bukhari 1469

The reply is already typed. Your thumb is ready to send it before you have decided whether you should. Part of you knows it may cost more than it gives, but the louder part does not care.

This chapter is about that brief moment before the reply leaves your phone, and what becomes possible when your first reaction does not get to lead.

Ayaan and the Hour Before Maghrib

The rejection came while Ayaan sat in his car outside the clinic, rain gathering on the windshield.

Thank you for completing the interview. After careful review, we have decided to move forward with another candidate.

That was it. No name, no feedback.

Two days earlier, he had spent an hour recording answers on a hiring platform that kept reminding him to look into the camera. There was no person on the other side, just a timer, a progress bar, and his own reflection trying to sound confident.

Tell us about a time you solved a problem.

Tell us why you are a good fit.

Tell us something unique about yourself.

Before the interview came the résumé. He had fed three years of his life into an AI tool, hoping automated screeners would read him more favorably. It checked keywords, rewrote bullet points, and congratulated him on his improved score.

Match the keywords. Beat the system. Be authentic but optimized.

It still did not work.

He was twenty-five. At his cousin's walima the month before, an uncle had asked what he was doing these days. Ayaan's answer bent under the weight

of expectation. A certificate became “training,” and applications became “a few things in motion.” The uncle nodded the way people nod at weather.

Inside the clinic, his name would be called soon.

“Just check the exhaustion,” his older brother Rayaana had said.

“Sometimes your body is carrying more than your pride will admit.”

Ayaan had rolled his eyes, mostly because it was true.

His phone lit up. His mother was calling. He answered.

Her voice was soft.

“Meri jaan, your father is asking if you heard back. I told him you are at the appointment.”

In the background, a cabinet shut hard. Then his father’s voice cut in.

“What appointment? Appointments cost money.” A pause. “Aftab Saheb’s son sent his parents for Umrah this year. He is one year younger.”

Then, quieter, almost to himself: “At twenty-five I had a family.”

“Ji, please,” his mother said, lower now. “He is trying. Don’t say it like that.”

“I am saying what needs to be said,” his father replied. “Everyone is stressed, not just him.”

There was a shift in the line, like the phone changing hands. Then her voice returned, softer.

“Beta, we’ll talk later. Focus on your appointment. Drive safely. Eat something.”

The call ended.

Ayaan sat completely still.

At twenty-five I had a family.

His body reacted at once. His jaw locked. Heat rose behind his ears. His shoulders tightened. His leg bounced hard enough to shake the keys, his breath grew shallow, and the phone felt warm in his hand.

He opened WhatsApp, held down the microphone button, and began recording a voice note for his mother.

“Everyone keeps saying take it seriously like I’m doing nothing. Do you think I like asking for help? Do you think I’m not trying?”

He stopped recording and listened to the voice note once. Every word was true, but hearing the anger in his own voice made the message feel more dangerous.

His thumb hovered over the send button. He was already thinking of recording a second voice note, the kind that sounds honest in the heat of anger but feels shameful when the heart grows quiet.

For a moment, he imagined what would happen if he sent it. Amma would find a private place, press play, and listen to his angry voice while deciding which parts to keep from his father.

He would not put her in that position. Not tonight.

He deleted the voice note instead of sending it. He was not calm yet, but he could see where it would lead: his mother trying to soften his words, his father becoming sharper, and the tension at home growing worse.

He put the phone face down as the clinic door opened and a name was called, not his.

He stepped out and stood under the awning. The air was cold; he breathed in, then out, slower. Again.

The rain continued. A child laughed inside, then started crying.

Ayaan almost smiled.

Then a line returned to him, something Rayaana had said:

“Breathe. Bismillah. Begin.”

At the time it had sounded simple; now it was clear.

His name was called.

Inside, the nurse checked his vitals and asked about sleep, stress, and fatigue.

This time, he answered directly.

“Yes, I am tired most days.”

“Yes, I stay up scrolling.”

“Yes, I feel pressure in my chest.”

No minimizing.

The doctor asked about his food, sunlight, concentration, and screen time, then ordered blood work to check for common issues.

“Fatigue can have several causes,” she explained. “Low vitamin D, iodine deficiency, or an underactive thyroid may make daily life feel more difficult. We’ll start with blood tests to find out whether any of these are affecting you.” She ordered the tests and asked him to schedule a follow-up appointment.

Ayaan nodded. There was no lecture and no quick fix, just a reminder that his body was not something to push through, but something to understand.

After the appointment, he walked outside. The rain had slowed, and his breathing was still heavy at first, but the movement gave the pressure somewhere to go.

By the time he returned to the car, the rejection was still there, but it was no longer controlling his attention.

He often found comfort in the recitations of Islam Sobhi and Omar Hisham, two reciters whose voices he returned to when he needed stillness. This time, he played Islam Sobhi’s recitation of Surah Ar-Rahman. He was not trying to escape what had happened; he was letting the measured rhythm slow his breathing and steady his focus.

وَرَتِّلِ الْقُرْآنَ تَرْتِيلاً

Recite the Qur'an with measured recitation. (73:4)

He followed its pace until the noise inside him began to quiet.

This rejection had not decided his rizq.

His breathing slowed, his shoulders dropped, and some of the tension in his body eased.

“Ya Allah,” he whispered, “don’t let this make me bitter. Show me the next step.”

The next step was simple: call Amma, tell the truth, and not send what would harm.

So he called.

“Amma, I heard back. I didn’t get it.”

There was a pause.

“And I almost sent something I would have regretted. I’m sorry.”

Her voice softened.

“Thank you for telling me, beta,” she said. “Come home. We’ll talk after Maghrib.”

After the call, he wrote down three goals: apply for two roles, go to sleep before midnight, and avoid comparisons that night.

Then he messaged Rayaana:

“I didn’t get it. I paused today. Can we plan after Maghrib?”

The reply came quickly.

“Proud of you.”

Ayaan read it twice.

On the drive home, the sentence returned: *At twenty-five I had a family.*

This time it came more quietly, wearing the voice of fact. Ayaan felt his jaw tighten. He breathed out longer than he breathed in and let the sentence pass without answering it. It was not gone; it simply was not driving anymore.

Nothing about the moment was impressive. The answer was still no, and tomorrow was still unwritten.

By the time Maghrib came in, he was still disappointed, but steady enough to pray.

And sometimes, that is where sabr begins.

That is the whole practice in one rainy hour. Now slow it down and look at what happened.

What Ayaan’s Pause Reveals

Nothing was solved. The rejection remained. His father’s words still stung, and the future was still unclear. What changed was his next choice.

He protected the next sixty seconds. That is where sabr begins: not when pain disappears, but when the first reaction no longer holds the wheel.

When the tongue could wound and the heart holds back, *hilm*, or forbearance, begins to grow.

To understand that kind of strength, sabr must be rescued from the idea that it is just quiet waiting.

What Is Sabr, and Why Is It More Than Waiting?

Sabr is pronounced SAH-br. It is one short word for a long kind of strength.

Sabr means steady endurance under pressure. The Arabic root means to bind, to hold in place; the early scholars called it ḥabs an-nafs, holding the self steady upon what Allah asks. In the Islamic tradition, sabr includes steadfastness in obeying Allah, restraint from disobedience, and endurance through hardship; this chapter focuses especially on the first moments of pressure. It is not passive waiting, and it is not pretending pain is easy. Least of all is it a name for letting harm continue.

Sabr is staying with what is right when the nafs pushes toward escape or reaction. It is continuing toward Allah while the hardship remains. The Qur'an commands believers to seek help through patience and prayer and promises that Allah is with the patient. Sabr is not only willpower. It is endurance with awareness of Allah. In one hadith, the Prophet ﷺ passed a woman crying beside a grave and urged her to fear Allah and be patient. Overcome by grief and not recognizing him, she told him to leave her because he had not suffered as she had. When she later learned who he was, she went to his home and explained that she had not recognized him. He replied, "Indeed, patience is at the first stroke of a calamity" (Sahih al-Bukhari 1283). The hadith speaks about the first shock of loss, when pain is most immediate and restraint is hardest. Its lesson is useful here too: sabr

is tested especially at the beginning of impact, when the first reaction presses hardest and Ayaan's thumb is hovering over send.

This is why sabr cannot be reduced to emotional regulation. Regulation can help steady a pressured moment, but sabr gives that steadiness a direction: stay with what is right, keep hold of hope when despair gets loud, and remain turned toward Allah while the hardship is still here. Sabr also leaves room for tears. Ya'qūb عليه السلام wept over Yusuf عليه السلام for years and still called his patience beautiful because he carried the grief to Allah rather than holding it against Him: "I only complain of my anguish and sorrow to Allah" (Surah Yusuf, 12:86). Feeling hurt does not disqualify patience.

For Ayaan, sabr looked small: deleting the message, putting the phone down, stepping outside, listening to Qur'an, and sending one honest response.

The Qur'an praises those who restrain anger and pardon people (Surah Ali 'Imran, 3:134). That is the doorway where hilm appears, but this chapter stays with the root that makes restraint possible: sabr under pressure.

Sabr gives the heart a faithful direction under pressure. Psychology helps explain what is happening in the mind and body during those same moments, and why a brief pause can make a wiser response possible.

Where Psychology Meets Sabr

Stress does not stay only in the mind. Under pressure, the body can react quickly. Breathing may change, muscles may tighten, and the heart may

beat faster. At the same time, it can become harder to hold several things in mind or shift away from the response that feels most urgent.

Psychologists use the “window of tolerance” to describe the emotional range in which a person can feel stress and still think clearly, stay present, and choose a response. Inside this range, you might feel upset by criticism but answer calmly, feel nervous before an interview but still focus, or handle a child’s tantrum without losing your temper. Outside this range, you might send an angry message, shout during an argument, panic and struggle to think, go quiet, feel numb, or become unable to respond.¹

That is when familiar escapes become tempting. We send sharp messages, keep arguing long after the conversation has stopped being useful, or scroll until we no longer must think about what happened.

Because pressure is also felt in the body, changing what the body is doing can help interrupt that momentum.

Slower breathing is one example. A 2022 systematic review and meta-analysis found that voluntary slow breathing changes heart rate and heart-rate variability. Newer studies have continued to report short-term increases in heart-rate variability, although protocols and populations vary.² A few slow breaths do not guarantee calm. They can, however, create a little space before the next decision.

Movement may help too. A short walk changes the setting and creates distance from the trigger. A 2024 meta-analysis of 113 studies involving 4,390 healthy young adults found a small overall benefit of a single bout of exercise for cognition, including reaction time; effects varied by task and

type of exercise.³ That evidence does not prove that every brief walk improves self-control, but it supports the broader idea that movement can help the mind reset.

Islamic guidance invites us to interrupt anger instead of letting it lead. Allah praises:

“Those who spend in prosperity and adversity, who restrain anger and pardon people. And Allah loves the doers of good.”

Surah Ali ‘Imran, 3:134

A hadith in *Sunan Abi Dawud* states:

“Anger is from Shaytan, and Shaytan was created from fire, and fire is extinguished by water; so when one of you becomes angry, let him perform wudu.”⁴

Wudu is first an act of purification that prepares us for worship. In a tense moment, it can also interrupt the course of anger. We step away, move toward water, wash with intention, and prepare to turn back to Allah. This simple physical sequence gives the body time to settle and gently shifts attention from reaction to worship.

This is what made Ayaan’s walk matter. The situation had not changed. He was still disappointed, and the message he had wanted to send in anger was still on his phone. But the pause gave him enough room to delete it and choose a response he could stand behind later.

These pauses do not create sabr. They make room for sabr to guide the next response.

What Qur'anic Engagement May Add

For the believer, its guidance, healing, and mercy do not depend on an experiment or a brain scan. Science can ask a narrower question: when people listen to, recite, memorize, or repeatedly engage with the Qur'an, what observable changes have researchers been able to measure?

I share this research not as proof of revelation, but as a careful look at outcomes researchers have measured. The studies are encouraging, yet many are small, varied in design, or at risk of bias.

A 2022 systematic review brought together 20 studies involving 2,566 participants, including healthy adults and people facing dialysis, heart disease, intensive care, pregnancy, and other forms of physical or emotional strain. Across these varied settings, Qur'anic listening, recitation, and memorization were associated with encouraging findings in anxiety, depression, sleep, quality of life, and several physiological measures.⁵

A 2023 scoping review examined 15 studies of Qur'anic recitation and listening. Most focused on anxiety, followed by stress and depression, and the overall findings were again favorable.⁶

Earlier controlled studies had already pointed in the same direction.

Research among patients receiving hemodialysis reported reductions in anxiety after listening to Qur'anic recitation. A 2018 systematic review also found that most of the studies it examined reported lower anxiety following Qur'anic recitation.⁷

Taken together, these reviews suggest that Qur'anic listening and recitation may support anxiety, stress, sleep, and quality of life in some settings. They do not yet establish how large or lasting the effects are, which practices work best, or whether the findings apply across populations. The most responsible conclusion is hopeful and modest: Qur'anic engagement may be a meaningful source of spiritual support, and it can complement appropriate medical or mental health care rather than replace it.

Qur'anic engagement is also a mentally active practice, drawing on sustained attention, careful listening, repetition, memory, and reflection.

Neuroscience-informed commentary by Muslim neuroscientist Mohamed Ghilan points out that traditional Qur'anic learning can involve close listening, precise pronunciation, repetition, retrieval, reading, review, and sometimes writing by hand. This is commentary rather than experimental evidence, but it highlights how actively attention and memory can be engaged. That matters here because pressure pulls attention toward what feels urgent, while Qur'anic engagement invites the believer to return deliberately to revelation.⁸

A 2025 systematic review included 22 EEG studies. Many reported changes in alpha and theta activity during Qur'an listening, which are patterns researchers often examine in relation to relaxed attention.⁹

An earlier 2022 review also described measurable neural and nervous-system responses during Qur'an listening. This remains a developing area of research, and its findings should be treated as observations about measurable responses, not as an explanation of revelation itself.¹⁰

Science can describe only part of the experience. It can study anxiety, sleep, attention, memory, heart rate, and patterns of electrical activity in the brain.

However, it cannot explain *hidayah*, revelation, barakah, or the awakening of the qalb.

Allah says:

“We send down of the Qur’an that which is healing and mercy for the believers.”

Surah Al-Isra, 17:82

Under pressure, Qur’anic remembrance brings the heart back to what is true, and to what Allah asks of it in that moment.

The difficulty may remain, and the conversation may still need to happen. Sabr is not the moment when everything settles; it is the moment when pressure no longer gets to choose the next word.

We meet these moments within real limits, strain, and the weight of ordinary days. Even so, the body is an amanah, and the next response still matters.

What follows is the same pause, broken into simple steps you can use before the next message is sent.

Applied Practice: Breathe. Bismillah. Begin.

Carry one practice from this chapter: the Three B’s: Breathe, Bismillah, Begin. Use them when the first wave of reaction rises: before you send the

voice note, before your reply sharpens, before the old pattern takes the wheel.

- **Breathe.** Take one slow breath out and interrupt the first surge. If you need to, step away, walk, or briefly name what is underneath the anger.
- **Bismillah.** Remember Allah as you choose your response. You are answering before Him now, not only reacting to the person in front of you.
- **Begin.** Take one sabr step you can stand behind: delete the message, tell the truth without wounding, make wudu, listen to a steady recitation, or choose the next responsible action.

Ayaan did not solve the rejection. He used the Three B's to keep disappointment from choosing the next word. That was enough to protect his mother, his heart, and the next hour.

Now the practice leaves Ayaan's parking lot and enters yours

End-of-the-Day Muhasabah: Where Did Pressure Rise Today?

Three short questions before you sleep. This is a quiet look back with Allah, not a scorecard. A word or a single line is enough.

1. When did pressure rise so quickly today that I wanted to react before pausing?

2. What helped me pause and use Breathe. Bismillah. Begin. even once before the reaction took over?

3. If this moment returns tomorrow, what sabr step will I take first, in shā' Allah?

Close with shukr for every sincere effort. Then set a simple niyyah before sleep: to meet tomorrow's pressure with sabr.

My Go-To Reminder

Protect the next response. Let sabr lead.

Du‘ā

يَا حَلِيمُ، يَا قَوِيٌّ، يَا مَتِينُ

Yā Ḥalīmu, yā Qawiyyu, yā Matīnu

O Allah: Al-Halīm, the Forbearing; Al-Qawiyy, the All-Strong; Al-Matīn, the Firm.

**Yā Rabbi, help me stay calm, speak with care, and avoid regret.
Bring my heart back to You, and give me sabr, hope, and sincerity.
Āmīn.**

Closing Reflection: The Next Response

Sabr can take different forms in different lives. It may mean returning after defeat, carrying responsibility through a changed season, or stepping back from competition long enough to heal. The stories of Ibtihaj Muhammad, Khadija Mardi, and Azizulhasni Awang show that this steady return belongs to neither one gender nor one kind of hardship.

At the 2016 Rio Olympics, Ibtihaj Muhammad became the first U.S. athlete to compete in hijab. She won her opening bout, then lost in the round of sixteen. Days later, she returned for the team sabre event and helped the United States win bronze.¹¹

Sabr does not promise medals or the endings we want. The lesson is quieter:

When loss had spoken, duty still called, and she answered by returning, showing that pain may mark one moment without writing the next.

Khadija Mardi offers another picture of that return. The Moroccan boxer reached the Olympic quarter-finals in 2016, missed the Tokyo Games after the birth of her third daughter, and kept training while carrying the demands of marriage, motherhood, and elite sport. In 2023, she became the first Arab and African woman to win a women's boxing world title.¹²

Her story does not make sabr look effortless. It shows steady effort through seasons when family responsibilities changed the path but did not erase the purpose. She returned without demanding that life become simple first.

Azizulhasni Awang provides another example of sabr. The Malaysian track cyclist won Olympic bronze in 2016 and silver at Tokyo 2020, building a career across five Olympic appearances despite being considered unusually small for his sport. After a high-speed training crash forced him to withdraw from the 2023 Asian Games, he accepted the medical decision, focused on recovery, and continued preparing for the next challenge.¹³

His sabr was not reckless endurance. It included restraint: stepping back when injury made competition unsafe, then returning to disciplined preparation. Alongside the women's examples, his story shows that sabr is not tied to one gender or one kind of hardship.

Most of our tests unfold far from Olympic lights: after rejection, during difficult conversations, or upon receiving news we cannot change. They unfold in ordinary hours, when disappointment rises to the tongue and asks to be released as harm.

The outcome is within Allah's decree, and we are still accountable for the response we choose. Sometimes sabr is simply this: returning with Allah to the work that remains and taking the next faithful step.

Key Takeaways

- Emotions are not the enemy; the first reaction simply does not have to lead.
- A brief pause can give the heart more room to choose wisely, even while pressure remains.
- Sabr protects the tongue, the hands, the phone, and the future self who must live with the response.
- Sometimes victory is not solving the whole situation. Sometimes it is simply protecting the next sixty seconds.

When sabr steadies you under pressure, what helps the heart release the outcome? Chapter 4 turns to tawakkul.

A Caution About Spiritual Practice and Professional Care

Spiritual practice can support well-being, but it does not replace routine medical care, screening, treatment, therapy, or crisis support. Faithfulness is not measured by whether you need help.

Caring for the body is part of honoring the amanah. Continue the preventive care your physician recommends, even when you feel well. If what you are carrying feels persistent, unsafe, or unmanageable, bring it to a qualified mental health professional or physician. If you are in immediate danger, contact your local emergency service.

Professional Support Note

This book is a companion. It offers reflective practices and evidence-informed tools, not therapy, medical advice, diagnosis, or crisis care. If repeated checking, reassurance-seeking, panic, intrusive thoughts, or persistent worry becomes difficult to manage, seek support from a qualified mental health professional or physician. For medical concerns, follow qualified medical guidance rather than using spiritual practice as a substitute for needed care. If you are in immediate danger, contact your local emergency service. Seeking help can be part of taking the means while relying upon Allah.

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DO NOT COPY

Chapter 4

Stop Guarding the Rope

Tawakkul After You've Done Your Part

THE VALUE Tawakkul

THE SCIENCE Acceptance

THE SHIFT Tie the camel, then let go

فَإِذَا عَزَمْتَ فَتَوَكَّلْ عَلَى اللَّهِ ۚ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ الْمُتَوَكِّلِينَ

Fa-idha 'azamta fatawakkal 'alallah. Innallaha yuhibbu-l-mutawakkilin.

So once you have made your decision, put your trust in Allah. Indeed, Allah loves those who put their trust in Him.

Qur'an, Surah Aal Imran, 3:159

A man asked the Prophet ﷺ: "Should I tie my camel and trust in Allah, or leave her untied and trust in Allah?" Hereplied: "Tie her, and trust in Allah."

Jami' al-Tirmidhi 2517

You have held a rope all day and called it responsibility. Some of it is. This chapter is about what is not.

Rayaan and Rania's story begins one early evening in their living room, with tea cooling on the table and two different worries already settling between them.

When Concern Becomes Control

The fairy lights had been up since last Eid, looped along the trim of the living room, and Rania had never taken them down because the room felt kinder with them on. It was early evening; the light was soft and gold. On the coffee table sat a pot of tea, still sweet with jaggery because Rayaan loved his sweets and Rania had quietly stopped trying to cut it, and a plate of homemade chicken patties cooling on a paper towel, the kind their daughter loved for the crisp edges more than the filling.

In the kitchen, Rania weighed Rayaan's favorite karak chai against her usual doodh patti. She made karak for both, smiling at how she had not known the difference before marrying him.

They had prayed Asr together a little earlier, Rayaan leading, Rania and their daughter in the row behind him, the little one going up and down half a second late, which was its own small mercy. For a few minutes after the salam, the evening had felt whole.

It had not been a whole afternoon, though. Soccer had been Rayaan's game since childhood, but two serious injuries had finally talked him into pickleball: Saturday games their friend Mina had organized, sisters on one court, brothers on the other. Most Saturdays that one hour belonged to nobody's expectations. Today he had not gone. He had meant to. Instead,

he sat with his laptop and his manager's email, refreshing job postings the way a thumb presses a bruise. The email was polite. Restructuring. Final contract decisions at the end of the month. There was nothing in it to argue with, nothing to hold, which somehow made it worse. He had checked the budget numbers, then checked them again, because anxious math has a way of pretending to be responsible math. By the time Asr came, the game was long over, and he had not moved the situation forward by a single inch.

He refreshed the page again, though nothing new would appear. The screen did not change, but his body still acted as if one more click might make uncertainty obey him. He closed the laptop, not because the worry disappeared, but because the next refresh was no longer responsibility. It was fear asking for control.

Now, on the couch, Rania lowered herself down with her own tea and her own phone. Her face tightened the way his shoulders had been tightening all day.

"Everything okay?" he asked.

"Nani Jan has a follow-up," she said, in the voice she used when she needed a thing to be nothing. "The doctor wants another test. It may be nothing."

Rayaan felt the words land somewhere older than the evening. His own Naani had been slower on the phone lately, her pauses stretching a little longer between sentences, and he had been telling himself it was the connection. Some part of him knew better.

He did not say it yet. He watched Rania's thumb hover over the search bar and recognized the motion, because he had done the same thing last Sunday, typing symptoms into his phone while Naani's voice replayed in his ear.

"You searched it?"

"Of course I searched it." She sighed. "The internet has never once told a worried granddaughter, please drink your tea and wait for the actual doctor."

Rayaan tried to smile. "I skipped the game today. Sat refreshing job sites instead." A short laugh with no humor in it. "As if one of them was going to say, Dear Rayaan, your future is secure, go play."

Without quite deciding to, he drew a slow breath in, held it a beat, and let it out longer than it came. Rania matched him, breath for breath. Neither named it. It had become one of those small tools that surface when an evening turns heavy. By the second round, their shoulders had come down a little. The worry was still there, but they had enough room to stay with the moment.

Rayaan looked at the email again. "It's not just the money," he said. "It's feeling helpless."

Her face softened. "That's the word. Helpless. I think that's what scares me too."

Once the fear had a name, it did not vanish, but it stopped leaking into everything.

“You know what I keep thinking about?” Rayaana said. “Summers at Naani’s. She let me stay up for the late-night ice cream, one spoon each, straight from the tub.”

Rania smiled without looking up. “Nani Jan used to save the best mango for me. She would play with me for hours, and when Amma and I disagreed, she always took my side.”

For a moment the worry loosened. The same two women who now needed doctors were the reason both knew, from childhood, what tenderness looked like.

On the coffee table was the small notepad Rania kept for groceries, half a list already on it: eggs, dish soap, that one spice they kept rebuying. Rayaana tore off a clean sheet. They had rescued an evening with a list before, at the kitchen table after Isha. This time the headings were different. He touched the pen to the page, took one more slow breath, and let the words become a quiet opening: Breathe. Bismillah. Begin. Then he wrote two headings. Mine to do. Not mine to control.

Under the first he wrote: update the resume, apply wisely, speak to my manager, review the budget once, and go to the game next week. He hesitated, then added the second column in smaller letters: the final decision, the timing, what people think, what Allah may open next. Rania held out her hand for the pen. Call Nani Jan, ask clear questions, help her prepare, make du’a. She glanced at him before the last column, and her writing slowed: the results, the waiting, the fear, what I cannot see yet.

Rayaan took back the pen and added, in smaller letters, under *Minetoda* call Naani this week—not to check on her, but to share the kind of talk they once had over ice cream.

“It’s annoying how short the first list is,” she said. “And how heavy the second one feels.”

The work remained. His contract was still pending. Her grandmother’s results were still unknown. The two lists did not erase the tasks, and they did not ask them to pretend they were not afraid. They simply stopped concerns from doing control’s job. His work was to prepare well, and to stop trading his Saturday hour for a refresh button that fixed nothing. Hers was to care tenderly. Their shared work was to make du’a without taking the outcome five minutes later.

That was the handoff. Not giving up. Giving over.

Rayaan set the pen down. Their daughter wandered over and ate the crisp edge off another patty. The two of them returned once more to the slow rhythm: breathe in, pause, breathe out longer. Then Rayaan said the words quietly, the old du’a of trust: sufficient for us is Allah, and He is the best disposer of affairs.

Rania repeated it under her breath. Sufficient for us is Allah.

Nothing was resolved; the email still sat on the table, and the test still waited on the calendar. They were simply no longer feeding the fear, under the fairy lights, with the tea going cold.

Later that night, with the house asleep and the fairy lights still on, Raya'an's phone lit up on the counter. A job alert. His thumb was moving before he had decided anything, the rope trying to climb back into his hand. He stopped. He turned the phone face down, said the words once more, quieter this time, and left the second column where they had put it.

Most real surrenders begin before certainty arrives.

That is the whole handoff in one evening; now slow it down and look at what happened.

What the Rope Was Really Holding

That evening's pattern was not irresponsibility but over-responsibility. Two careful people kept checking because they felt protective. The mind treats information like a rope: one more search, one more refresh, and perhaps the future will hold still.

Sometimes the next step is clear: call the doctor, submit the form, ask the question, make the appointment, apologize, or follow up once. Yet fear may still demand more: check again, ask again, imagine every outcome.

Tawakkul helps us notice when responsibility has become repetition.

Tawakkul became necessary once fear had its true name: helplessness.

Named, it could be sorted. The two lists drew a line between what their hands could reach and what only Allah holds.

The shift took two short lists and one verse spoken aloud. Nothing on the calendar changed, but the evening stopped rehearsing every outcome. Not giving up. Giving over.

To trust like that, tawakkul first has to be rescued from the idea that it is giving up.

What Is Tawakkul, and How Is It Different from Giving Up?

For the record: ta-WAK-kul, stress in the middle

Tawakkul means relying upon Allah while taking the means He has placed within your reach. It is not carelessness, and it is not spiritual laziness wearing a pious coat. That one has a name: tawākul, trust with the effort left out. It leaves the work undone and still calls itself trust. The Prophet ﷺ did not tell the man to leave his camel untied. Tie her, he said, and trust in Allah.

Tying the camel means applying for the role, calling the doctor, apologizing sincerely, saving what you can, asking for advice, and having difficult conversations. Releasing the rope means remembering that your effort matters, but the outcome belongs to Allah. Tie the camel. Stop pulling the rope after it is tied.

Tawakkul also has an afterward. It does not call every loss easy, and it does not pretend pain feels good. It means that when the outcome arrives, the heart may grieve, but it does not turn bitter toward the One who sees the

whole story. You do what is yours to do, then trust the One who plans with perfect wisdom.

That trust is spiritual, but the urge to keep checking lives in the body.

Where Psychology Meets Tawakkul

Uncertainty can make the mind reach for another search, refresh, or question. When no new information has appeared and the next responsible step remains unchanged, that checking may offer only brief relief before the urge returns.¹

Psychological acceptance means allowing uncertainty to remain without treating it as a command to keep seeking relief. It helps us recognize the checking cycle and return to the next responsible action.²

Psychology and tawakkul address connected parts of the struggle.

Psychology helps us respond wisely to uncertainty; tawakkul adds the spiritual handoff. After taking the means within our reach, we entrust the outcome and the unseen to Allah. Acceptance makes room for uncertainty; tawakkul reminds the heart Who holds what it cannot control.

Ibn al-Qayyim wrote in *Madarij al-Salikin*:

مدخول فتوكله نفاها من فإن، والمسببات الأسباب إثبات.

*Recognizing means and their effects is part of tawakkul; whoever denies the means has a deficient tawakkul.*³

Taking the means belongs to tawakkul, but acting well does not make the outcome ours. If the result is painful, sabr and submission help us accept it as part of the qadar of Allah.

What follows is that handoff, broken into steps small enough to use tonight.

Applied Practice: The Tawakkul Boundary

When you notice yourself circling the same concern, return to four questions:

1. What is mine to do?
2. What have I already done?
3. What am I repeating from fear?
4. What do I now entrust to Allah?

For Rayaan, it meant updating the résumé, applying wisely, speaking with his manager, and reviewing the budget once. The refreshing was the part fear kept asking him to repeat; the decision and its timing were not his to manage.

For Rania, it meant calling Nani Jan, asking clear questions, helping with the appointment, following the doctor's guidance, and making du 'ā. The late-night searching could not give her the certainty she wanted.

Sometimes the boundary is practical: no portal checking after Isha, no major decision made in panic, and no reopening the same question unless new information has appeared.

And the handoff has words when you need them, the du 'a of the believers in Surah Ali Imran, 3:173:

حَسْبُنَا اللَّهُ وَنِعْمَ الْوَكِيلُ

Hasbunallahu wa ni'mal wakil.

Sufficient for us is Allah, and He is the best disposer of affairs.

Tawakkul trusts Allah before the outcome; qadar accepts what Allah brings after it.

First, though, the day itself deserves an honest look back.

End-of-the-Day Muhasabah: Where Did I Reclaim Control?

Before sleep, reflect briefly and honestly, not as a scorecard. Answer each question in one line.

1. When did I reach for control again today after doing my part?

2. What was mine to do?

3. What will I entrust to Allah tonight?

4. If the worry returns tomorrow, what will be mine to do, and what will I leave with Allah, in shā' Allah?

My Go-To Reminder

Take the wiser step. Trust Allah with the outcome.

Du‘ā

يَا وَكِيلُ، يَا حَفِيزُ، يَا فَتَّاحُ

Yā Wakīlu, yā Hafīzu, yā Fattāhu

O Allah, Al-Wakæl, the Trustee of all affairs, Al-Hafæz, the Preserver, Al-Fattah, the Opener,

Yā Rabbi, teach me to entrust to You what my hands cannot hold.

Guard my heart from panic, open what worry cannot open, and gently close what is not meant for me. Help me do my part with sincerity, then rest in Your wisdom, relying on You before the outcome and remaining steadfast afterward. Protect those I love and provide for those entrusted to my care. Whether a door opens or closes, keep my heart close to You. Help me do what is mine today and leave tomorrow in Your hands.

Āmīn.

Closing Reflection: Two Moments of Trust

Tawakkul does not always meet us in the same kind of moment.

Sometimes it comes after careful planning. Sometimes it comes when strength is thin and all we can manage is the next step.

During the Hijrah, the Prophet ﷺ and Abu Bakr رضي الله عنه planned carefully, arranged support, and took the means available to them. Still, danger came close. In the cave, the Qur'an preserves the Prophet's ﷺ words to his companion: "Do not grieve. Indeed, Allah is with us" (Surah At-

Tawbah, 9:40). Their preparation mattered, but it was never the source of their safety.

Maryam عليها السلام faced a very different moment. The pains of childbirth brought her to the trunk of a palm tree in deep distress. She was told not to grieve, but to shake the trunk, eat and drink, and take comfort (Surah Maryam, 19:23–26). Even there, she was given a next step.

These are different moments. The cave shows trust after preparation. Maryam's story shows trust when the next step is small. Neither makes human effort the source of the outcome. The believer does what is within reach, then leaves what comes next to Allah.

Some days you will have a plan: make the call, submit the application, ask the question, prepare well. Other days, the most faithful thing you can do may be one small step. Tawakkul holds both. Tie the camel when there is something to tie. Shake the palm tree when the next step is small. Then stop asking your hands to carry what belongs to Allah. The hands keep working. The heart learns to release.

Key Takeaways

- Tawakkul does not ask us to abandon the means or turn them into guarantees.
- Use the Tawakkul Boundary: take the step that is yours, then let Allah hold what your hands cannot.
- Acceptance helps you live with uncertainty without repeatedly searching for reassurance or control. Tawakkul helps you entrust the outcome to Allah after you have done what is within your responsibility.

- Sometimes the next act of trust is closing the tab, putting the phone down, and letting the night end.
- The hands work. The heart rests.

The outcome is handed over. But there is one more rope, the one tied to how you speak to yourself when you drop something. Untying that one with mercy is Chapter 5.

Notes

1. Rector, Neil A., Katy Kamkar, Stephanie E. Cassin, Lindsay E. Ayearst, and Judith M. Laposa. "Assessing Excessive Reassurance Seeking in the Anxiety Disorders." *Journal of Anxiety Disorders*, vol. 25, no. 7, 2011, pp. 911–917. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.janxdis.2011.05.003>. See also Paul M. Salkovskis and Osamu Kobori, "Reassuringly Calm? Self-Reported Patterns of Responses to Reassurance Seeking in Obsessive Compulsive Disorder," *Journal of Behavior Therapy and Experimental Psychiatry* 49 (2015): 203–208. DOI: 10.1016/j.jbtep.2015.09.002. [Back]
2. Hayes, S. C., Strosahl, K. D., and Wilson, K. G. *Acceptance and Commitment Therapy: The Process and Practice of Mindful Change*. 2nd ed., Guilford Press, 2011. [Back]
3. Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyya. *Madarij al-Salikin*, on reliance upon Allah and the taking of means. [Back]

Professional Support Note : This book is a companion. It offers reflective practices and evidence-informed tools, not therapy, medical advice, diagnosis, or crisis care. If repeated checking, reassurance-seeking, panic, intrusive thoughts, or persistent worry becomes difficult to manage, seek support from a qualified mental health professional or physician. For medical concerns, follow qualified medical guidance rather than using spiritual practice as a substitute for needed care. If you are in immediate danger, contact your local emergency service. Seeking help can be part of taking the means while relying upon Allah.